FREIGHT UNIVERSITY

THE ART OF THE DEAL WITH 10 WHEELS



MICHAEL THOMAS

A truck moves in a straight line. **A business moves in circles.**

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY LIBRARY

THE ART OF THE DEAL WITH 10 WHEELS

A license is not a business. A deal is.
2026 edition, rewritten November 2026

MICHAEL THOMAS

freightuniversity.online

What's inside

Before you turn the first wheel 4

Think in circles 5

The First Decision 7

The First Deal 10

The Where and the Who 13

The Million-Dollar Handshake 16

A License Is Not a Business, a Deal Is 19

The Art of Passive Trucking 22

Owning Both Sides of the Road 25

Building the Deal, Not Just the Load 28

The 10-Wheel Playbook 31

Compliance Is King 34

The Triangle 38

The Dispatch Command Center 42

The Way Out 46

The wheel never stops 50

About the author 51

Where things come from 52

Before you turn the first wheel

All right. Let me tell you why this book exists.

For the first fifteen years of my working life, I wasn't in logistics at all. I was doing other things. When I came into freight, I brought my old way of thinking with me, and it didn't work. Most people who come into this business do the same thing. They come from healthcare, from corporate jobs, from a driver's seat, and they think, "I'm going to build this, I'm going to go this direction, I'm going to have that."

Then they find out what this business really is. You can't do any of it by yourself.

Think about it. What's a driver? What's a broker? Who's the dock manager? Who handles the compliance? Who pays the invoice? Every single thing you're trying to do runs through another person. And the only way anything happens between two people in business is a deal.

It took me more than twenty years to understand that. I really don't know a better name for it than the art of the deal. It's the subject I think should come first in anybody's training, and I'd like you to hear it before you've spent your money, not after.

I want to be straight with you about what this is. It's one of my thinking books. There's no test at the end. It won't teach you how to fill out a form or which screen to tap. The courses do that. This book is here to invoke your thinking, which is my way of saying I want you to stop and use your own head before you act.

What's inside

There are thirteen turns, and each one ends with two short things. Think in Circles asks what that turn feeds and how it comes back to you. Your Turn gives you something to do with a pencil.

Meet Rosa and Sam

You'll follow two people the whole way. Rosa owns Cedar Ridge Transport, one 53-foot dry van out of Memphis, and she drives the truck herself. A dry van's the plain closed trailer that hauls boxes, paper goods and furniture. Sam's a PLSP, a Professional Logistics Service Provider, which means he's the back office a small trucking company can't afford to hire on its own.

> **ONE THING TO KNOW**
>
> Rosa, Sam and every company, person and dollar amount in their story are made up for training. Copy the thinking. Don't copy the numbers. When I tell you about my own experience, I'll say it's mine. And I don't print what you're going to earn, because I can't promise it. It depends on your deals.

Think in circles

Most people read a business book looking for a straight line. Do this, then that, then you win. Put that down, because freight doesn't work that way.

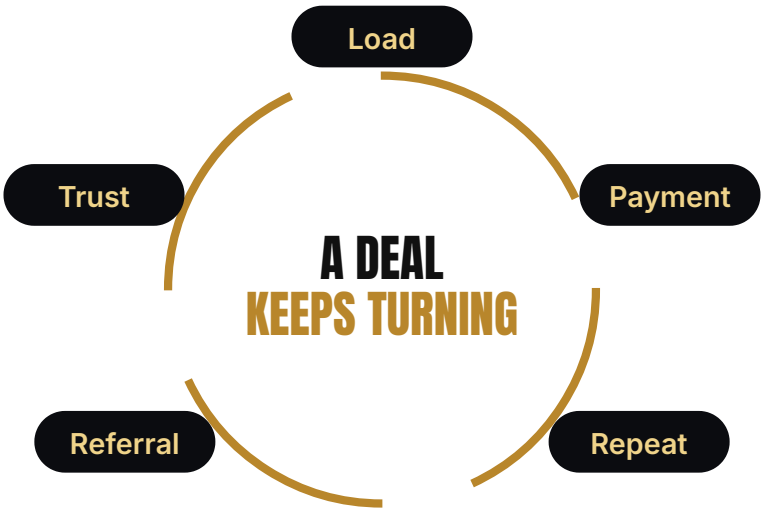
Straight-line thinking asks one question: what's happening right now? Then it stops.

Circular thinking keeps going. What will this set in motion? What happens after that? And how does it come back around to where I started?

Watch it on the road. Rosa hauls a load for a shipper and calls ahead when traffic backs up in Birmingham. That's one load. The shipping manager remembers the call. The next time she's got something tough to move, she thinks of Rosa. That load turns into a regular lane. The regular lane lets Rosa promise her driver a schedule. The driver stays. A driver who stays shows up on time, and the shipper tells somebody else about it.

Every point on that ring feeds the next one. Nothing you do ends where it happens.

Here's the difference in one line, and you'll hear me say it again: **a load ends at the dock. A deal keeps turning.** Invoice, payment, repeat, referral.



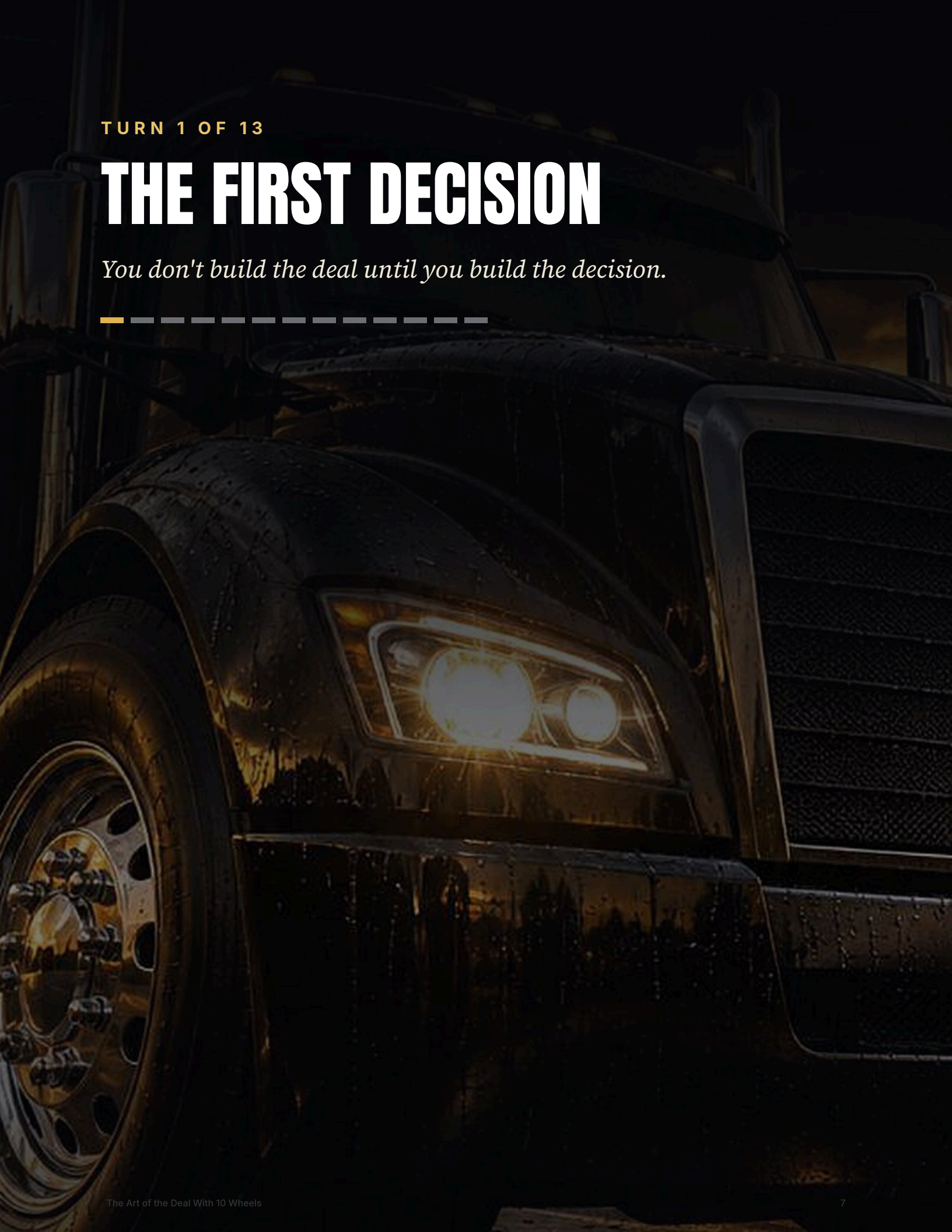
The person who thinks in straight lines burns out chasing the next load. Every Monday, they start over from zero. The person who thinks in circles starts every Monday from wherever last week left them.

That's the real skill in this book. I'm not handing you a list of moves. I'm trying to show you how to see the whole wheel while everybody else stares at one spoke.

TURN 1 OF 13

THE FIRST DECISION

You don't build the deal until you build the decision.



When Sam met Rosa, she already had her truck and she was tired of coming home empty. She'd been running whatever got posted, and she had a head full of ideas. "I'm thinking I add a flatbed," she told him, "and maybe some reefer in the summer, and a guy told me auto hauling pays great."

Sam let her talk. Then he asked one question. "What kind of operator do you want to be?"

She didn't have an answer. Most people don't. They've thought about the truck, the paint job and the name on the door. They haven't thought about what they're building.

Before you buy a truck, file for authority or call your first shipper, sit down and answer this. Am I picking up a gig, one load at a time? Or am I building something that gets stronger and worth more every year? That one answer touches everything after it: your freight, your lanes, your equipment, your drivers, even your insurance bill.

Do one thing, and do it well

That's the rule I've lived by in every business I've had. When I got into something, that's all I did until it was working.

In freight, the first thing you pick is the trailer, because the trailer decides the industry. General freight rides in a dry van. Steel and lumber ride on a flatbed, an open trailer with no walls. Food that has to stay cold rides in a reefer, a refrigerated trailer. Pick the trailer and it decides the shippers you'll call, the drivers you'll look for and the research you'll do. It's like dominoes.

And freight isn't only freight. Each kind comes with its own waiting time, its own kind of driver and its own bills. Choose what fits your life and your money.

Five questions before you spend anything

1. What freight fits where I'm trying to go?
2. Local, regional, or across the country? What does that do to my home life, or my driver's?
3. Can my life and my family carry the pressure while this gets going?
4. Do I know my breakeven, what it costs me to run one mile, before I ever quote a rate?
5. Do I have money set aside for repairs, and can I afford the insurance on the freight I picked?

Don't quit your job

People ask me all the time, "Should I quit my job?" The answer's no. Never stop your income. A business has to be built from an income. You don't quit and expect something magical to happen in six months. If you want to take that risk it's your call, but I won't tell you to.

Rosa didn't buy the flatbed. She stayed with one trailer, the dry van. She picked one region, around Memphis, where she knew the roads and could sit across a table from people. It wasn't exciting. It was a decision, and now every other decision had something to stand on.

I've met the other kind. I knew a person who bought five trucks before they had one driver. Then what? Now you're out searching for strangers to hand hundreds of thousands of dollars of equipment to. The decision came last, and that's backward.

THINK IN CIRCLES

Your first decision isn't a finish line. It's the first turn of the wheel. Don't ask only "what do I pick?" Ask "what will this set in motion, and how does it come back to me?"

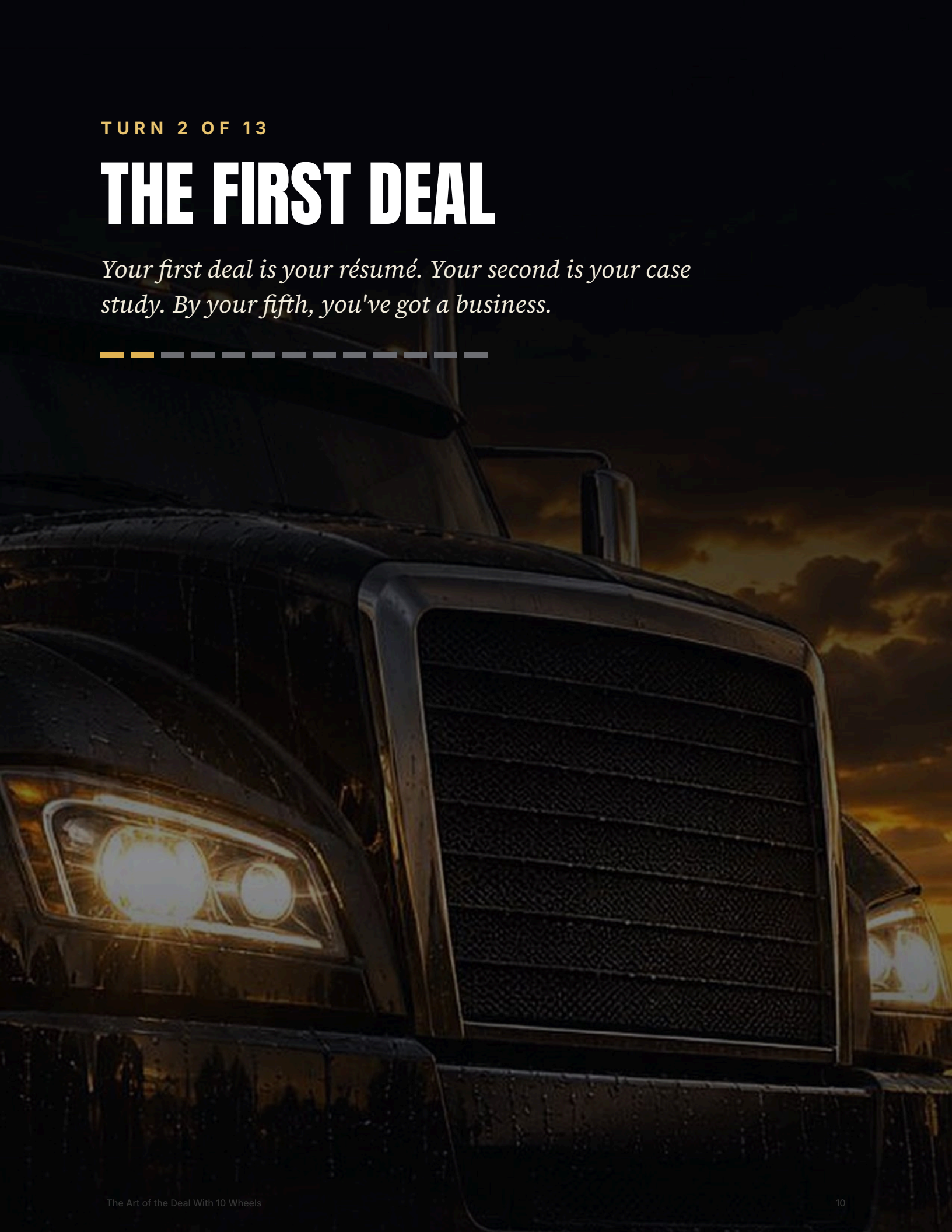
YOUR TURN

Answer the five questions on paper, in pencil. Then finish this sentence: "I'm building ___, with ___ trailer, in ___ region, because ___." If you can't finish it, you're not ready to spend money yet, and now you know what to work on.

TURN 2 OF 13

THE FIRST DEAL

Your first deal is your résumé. Your second is your case study. By your fifth, you've got a business.



There's a moment you'll remember. The day it stops being paperwork and starts being income.

For Rosa and Sam, it wasn't a big contract. Sam had done his freight research around Memphis and called a broker for Cedar Ridge. Rosa ran a load of paper goods from Memphis to Atlanta for $1,650. They both paid attention the whole way, and they finished knowing something they hadn't known that morning.

Rosa knew who paid her, and when. She knew what she'd agreed to do and what would happen if she didn't. She knew what the truck really cost her that trip and what was left over.

That's what a first deal teaches you: how money moves in this business. Who pays. How often. Who's responsible for what. Where the margin lives, and margin just means what's left after the cost of doing the work.

What's in a deal

A deal in freight isn't a handshake and a hope. It has four parts.

- **The freight.** Somebody has something that needs to move.
- **The capacity.** Somebody has the right truck, the right trailer and the right driver.
- **The agreement.** The rate, in writing, and what everybody's promised to do.
- **The plan.** Pickup number, appointment time, who calls who, and what happens if it goes wrong.

Miss one and you don't have a deal. You have a conversation.

And notice who I left off that list. You. Freight doesn't move itself. Somebody has to bring those four things together and hold them together, and that's the deal maker. People think the driver makes it happen, or the equipment does. It happened because you said it would, and you made sure of it.

A man's word is his bond

I say that to every class, and in this business it isn't just a saying. Freight runs on trust. One missed call can lose you a shipper. One broken promise can ruin a lane. But when people know that if you said it's going to happen it's going to happen, doors open that no amount of advertising will open.

The paper trail

Keep your word, and get it in writing. A deal isn't real until it's documented. Before Rosa's truck turned a wheel she had the broker's carrier agreement, the rate confirmation (the paper that sets the deal for one load) and a pickup number she had verified. She never moves a load without verifying that number.

Think past the one load

Ask where this deal sends you. A good one leads somewhere: a repeat lane, a shipper's name, a broker who calls you first. The smart people in this business aren't chasing random freight. They're looking for the same work again, in a region they know, with the equipment they've got.

THINK IN CIRCLES

One deal is never one deal. A finished load plants the next one: the relationship, the reputation, the lane. Trace where this one sends you.

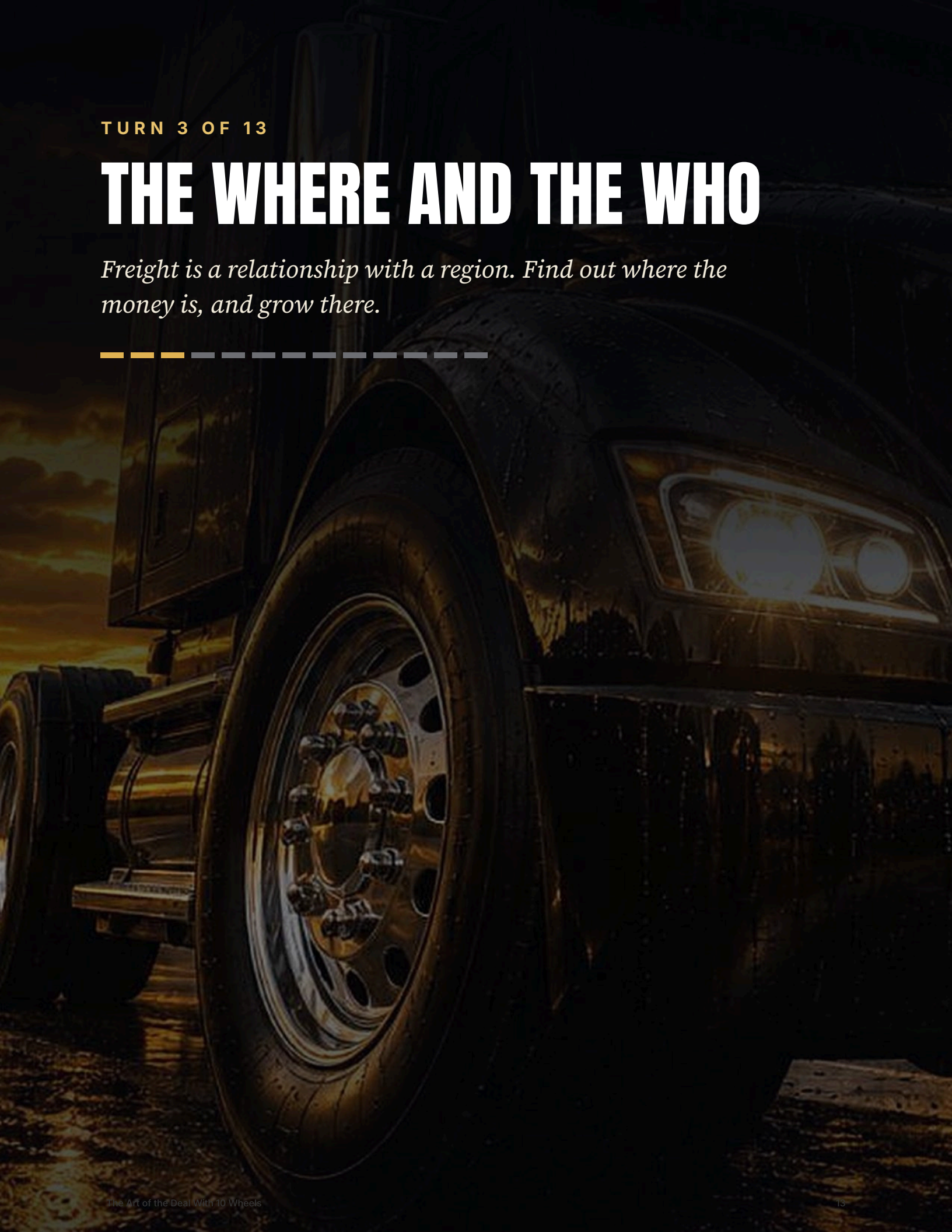
YOUR TURN

Take any load you've run or studied, even a made-up one. Write down the four parts of the deal. Then write who gets paid, by whom, and when. If you can't answer those last three, that's what you need to learn first.

TURN 3 OF 13

THE WHERE AND THE WHO

Freight is a relationship with a region. Find out where the money is, and grow there.



I've watched people buy the truck and get the authority without ever asking the real question: where's the freight, and who's moving it?

Freight isn't spread out evenly across America. It flows through certain lanes, ports, rail yards and factory towns. A lane's just a route trucks run regularly, like Memphis to Atlanta. If you don't know your region, you're running blind.

The where

Start close to home, and study these:

- Where the distribution centers and factories are around you
- Which lanes fit your trailer
- What changes with the season, like produce, holidays and construction
- Where new warehouses are going up
- Where a truck that delivers there can find its way back out

If you run reefer, why wouldn't you study where the produce season hits? If you run flatbed, which states have the steel and the lumber? That's freight research, and it's the heart of everything we teach. A true dispatcher is a freight researcher, and so is a good broker and a good carrier.

The who

Behind every load there's a person who decides. Behind every lane there's a shipper. Learn who they are:

- Brokers who work your lanes and your kind of trailer
- Shippers with freight that repeats
- Dock managers who know what's really going on
- Drivers who live near you and know the region

Be somebody who knows. I call it being a walking encyclopedia of freight. If you know where the freight is and you know your lanes, you can lay out the dots for a carrier and they'll follow you. They'll do it once. If you've done your homework, they'll keep doing it.

Don't sit around waiting, either. Nobody's going to come beating on your door. You go to theirs. Set up a meeting with a carrier near where you live. Sit down face to face.

Stay close enough to be held accountable

That goes for drivers too. If I hire a driver out of California and I'm in the backwoods of Georgia, how do I sit down with that person when something goes wrong?

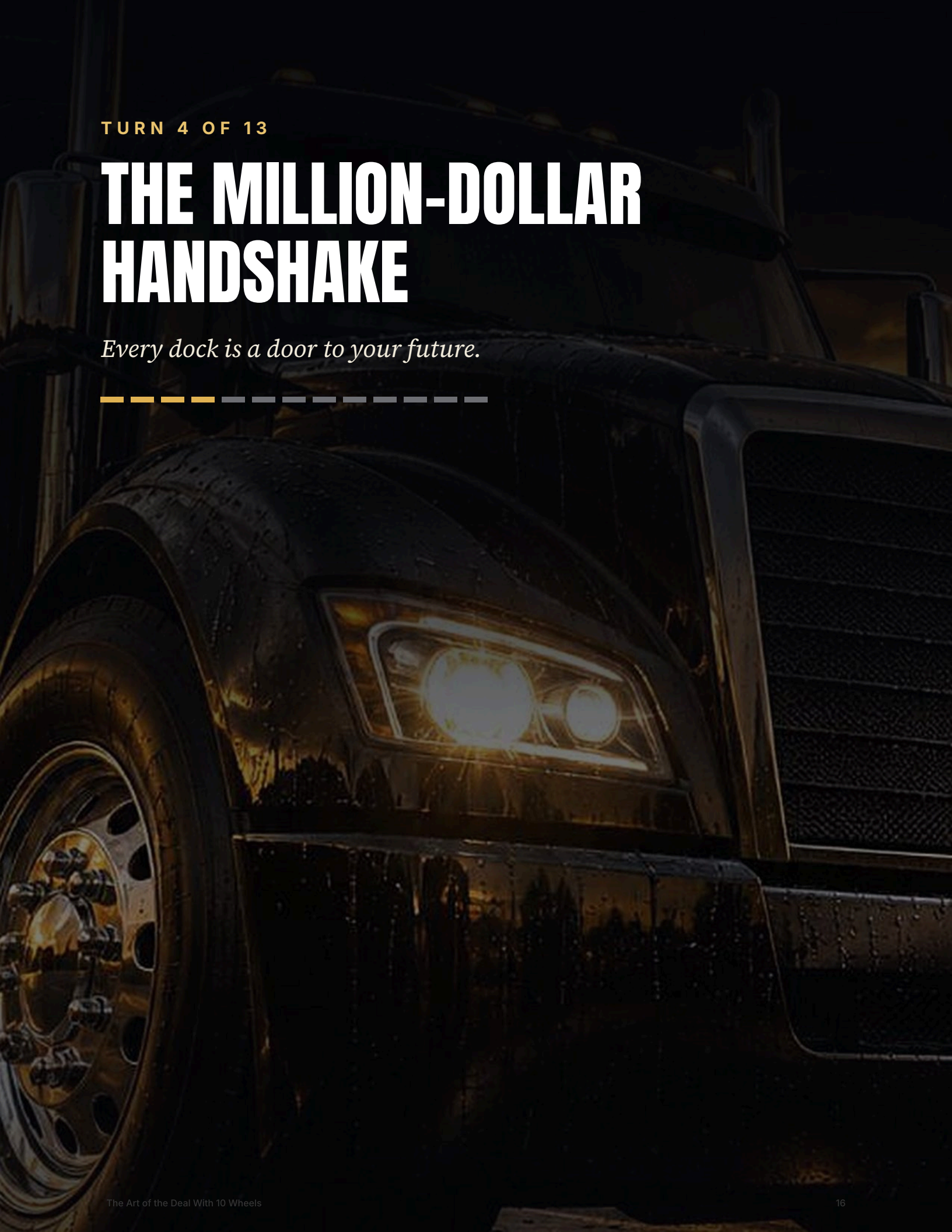
Rosa and Sam made one sheet of paper: the shippers within 50 miles of Memphis, like Bluff City Foods, what each one ships, and the brokers who post dry van there. It took a couple of weeks of evenings. By the end, Sam could tell Rosa things about her own town she'd driven past for years.

THINK IN CIRCLES

A lane and a contact aren't a destination. They're a loop. The shipper you find today tells you which carrier you need tomorrow, and that carrier sends you a referral next month.

YOUR TURN

Draw a 50-mile circle around where you live. List five places inside it that ship freight, and what trailer that freight would need. Don't look anything up on a load board yet. Drive around if you have to.



TURN 4 OF 13

THE MILLION-DOLLAR HANDSHAKE

Every dock is a door to your future.

The best deals I've seen didn't start on a screen. They started with two people talking. Every dock you walk onto, every call with a dispatcher, every driver check-in is a chance at something bigger than the load in front of you.

I call it the million-dollar handshake. That isn't a promise of a million dollars. It's what one good relationship can turn into when you repeat it.

The driver's the first handshake

The number one thing that destroys most trucking companies is the driver. Think about what we're doing. We put hundreds of thousands of dollars into equipment and hand it to somebody we barely know.

Somebody called me not long ago because their driver left the truck and trailer at a truck stop, called a ride and quit. It cost thousands of dollars to get that equipment back, and the load was late. I had a driver of my own get hot over a question and tell me, "I'll pull this thing over and just leave it." They know they've got you.

So how do you change that? Purpose. Give somebody a reason to drive for you that isn't three more cents a mile.

Your job is to be the information of the freight. Their job is to take the deal and get it delivered. When you bring on a driver, that person's almost a business partner, and that decision doesn't need to happen overnight. I don't mean a legal partnership unless your attorney wrote one up. I mean you sit down and say, "Here's my plan. I'm not asking you to just be a driver. Here's how we can grow this together."

Look near home first, and look for at least two years of experience with a clean record. Less than that can raise your insurance cost, so ask your agent before you decide. Go where drivers are: truck stops, fuel stations, CDL schools, your own town. Buy a coffee. Ask questions and listen. Plenty of good drivers are tired of broken promises.

My other two books go deep on this. The Right Seat is about hiring your first driver, and Drivers Before Trucks is about why that skill comes before the equipment.

What a good driver sees

A good driver doesn't only drive. They're on every dock. They see which shipper keeps trucks waiting and they hear about the new warehouse before anybody posts a load out of it. Teach them what to listen for, and they'll bring you things no load board ever will.

When Rosa hired for her second truck, she told the driver, "If you see a shipper we should know about, get me the name." Three weeks later a text came in with a photo of a sign at a paper plant and a phone number for the shipping office. It was only a name on a sign, and

Sam had a new call to make.

What it does for you

A driver who stays cuts your turnover. Replacing people costs time and costs customers. A driver who stays knows the route and the docks, so your service gets steadier. And brokers and shippers want certainty as much as they want coverage. Steady service gives you something real to stand on when you talk about the rate.

Don't forget the other handshakes

There's nothing wrong with two trucking companies working together. They don't have to compete. Build your network of carriers. Represent them. Combine capacity, and shippers' doors open.

Keep it professional, though. You want drivers and partners who'll build with you, not run you. I told a driver not long ago, "Man, I think I work for you."

THINK IN CIRCLES

A handshake doesn't end at hello. Trust earns freight, freight earns more trust, and that trust brings you the next person.

YOUR TURN

Write the names of five people in your area who touch freight. Dock worker, driver, CDL instructor, shop owner, anybody. Which one could you buy a coffee this week? What's one question you'd ask, and then be quiet and listen?

TURN 5 OF 13

A LICENSE IS NOT A BUSINESS, A DEAL IS

Paper don't pay. Partnerships do.



Here's one of the most dangerous ideas in trucking: that once your authority comes through, you're in business. I've watched people frame the paperwork and celebrate. Then the phone doesn't ring, and the insurance bill does.

Your authority is permission. That's all it is. It's the government saying you may operate. It doesn't find a shipper, it doesn't sign a driver and it doesn't pay you. A deal does.

Plain words. A USDOT number identifies your company to the federal government. Operating authority, which for years has come with what we call an MC number, is your permission to haul freight for pay across state lines, or to broker it. FMCSA is the federal agency over trucking, and it's looking at phasing MC numbers out in favor of the DOT number. When you read this, check what's current.

A clean record gets more valuable with time

That's still true, and it's why you take care of your authority from day one. Time in business counts. Plenty of brokers and shippers won't touch a brand-new carrier, and each company sets its own rule about how new is too new. Insurance is usually hardest in the early years. A company with a few clean years, steady freight, good drivers and a good safety history gets calls a new company doesn't.

So don't treat your authority like a trophy. Treat it like a reputation that's being built whether you're paying attention or not. Every load, every inspection and every late payment goes into it.

Don't buy somebody else's number

I need to correct something, because I used to teach this differently. An earlier edition of this book told you to look for an older authority for sale. Don't do it.

In March 2026, FMCSA put out a bulletin that said it plainly: do not sell, purchase or lease a USDOT number or operating authority, online or anywhere else, from an unknown person or outside a legitimate corporate transaction. FMCSA says it will inactivate the number and start proceedings to revoke all the registrations tied to it. A person who sold an authority without doing the transfer properly was held responsible after a later crash.

Buying a real company, the whole business with its legal entity and its records, is a different thing from buying a number. That's a corporate transaction, and FMCSA has its own conditions for it, like the operation continuing under the same safety management, so you do it with a transportation attorney. If somebody's offering you an aged MC on the internet, walk away. There are too many sharks out there already.

Build the house people want to live in

Here's where the circle starts. When a company's got a real system, people want to be part of it. Brokers call it first. Shippers send it freight. Drivers want to work there. Other owners may want to put their truck on under it.

That last one has rules. Running somebody else's truck under your authority takes a written lease that meets federal leasing rules (49 CFR Part 376), plus your insurance company's agreement, and you're responsible for that truck's safety record. It can be done right, and I'd have an attorney write it. Your name is on it now.

Now the math changes. One truck runs consistently, so you add a second on the same lane. Those two start to look like capacity to a shipper. You go from taking what's posted to being asked what you can do.

The moment you shift from "what can I get with this license?" to "what can I build with other people?", it all starts to open up.

THINK IN CIRCLES

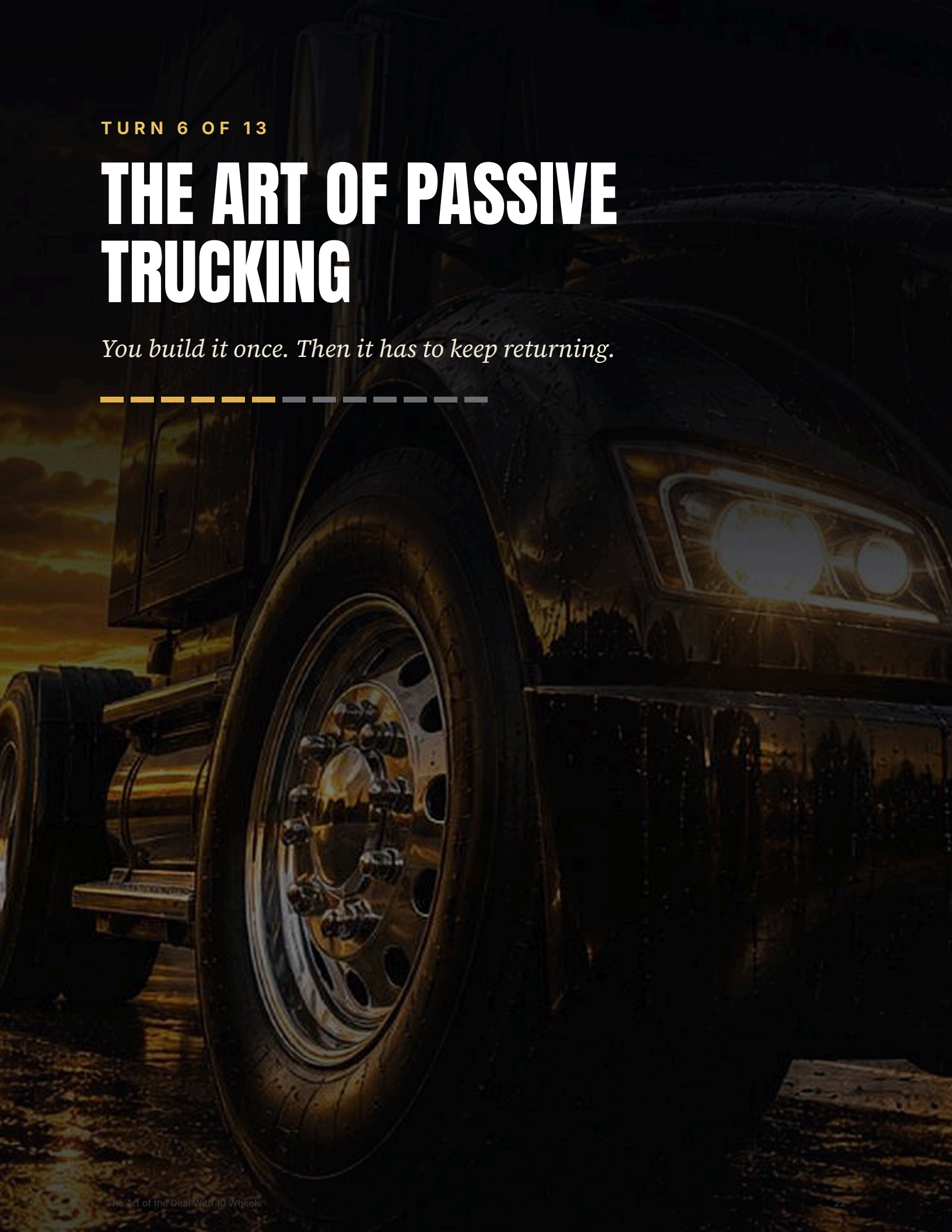
Paper sits still. A deal moves and comes back. Ask what keeps the wheel turning after the authority prints.

> **YOUR TURN**
>
> If somebody looked up your company today, what would they find? If you don't have one yet, write three things you'd want them to find five years from now. Then write what you'd have to do this month for that to be true.

TURN 6 OF 13

THE ART OF PASSIVE TRUCKING

You build it once. Then it has to keep returning.



I've taught passive income trucking for a long time, and it's one of the most misunderstood things I talk about. So let me tell you what it is and what it isn't.

It starts simple. Somebody owns a truck. Somebody who knows what they're doing manages it. The truck moves real freight and the owner gets a real report on what it earned and what it cost. Think of owning rental property, except the tenant's a load.

Now the honest part

Passive doesn't mean nothing can go wrong. A truck can sit. A driver can quit. A repair bill can eat a month. The owner's still the owner and still pays for what an owner pays for. Nobody can promise you a number every week, and I'd be careful of anybody who does. I'd ask to see their books, and I'd pay a professional to read them.

Passive is a word for what the owner's day looks like. It doesn't describe the work. Somebody's doing that work, and it had better be somebody good.

Own the system, not just the truck

Here's the part I want you to think hardest about. Parking your money in one truck is one thing. Learning to run the system that truck sits in is something else entirely.

The truck's the model. Once it works, you know what it takes to do it again: the lane, the driver deal, the dispatch, the back office. That's what can be repeated. Income that only comes when you're personally on the phone is a job. A business keeps going while you're building the next relationship.

So invoke your thinking. Ask yourself:

- How would this run if I weren't here every day?
- What would I need in place for ten trucks instead of one?
- Who are the people I'd need?

Build it backward

1. Write down where you're going. What's the size you want? What do you want your days to look like?
2. Work back to the lanes and the freight it would take.
3. Write your playbook. How does a load get booked here? Who does what?
4. Train everybody the same way, so your company speaks one language.
5. Then, and only then, automate. Software speeds up what's already working. It won't fix what isn't.

Pick your people carefully

I've watched models that looked great on paper fall apart because the people weren't on the same page. You need a dispatcher who knows lanes and respects the driver's clock. You need somebody who can talk to brokers and shippers and get repeat freight. You need somebody who keeps every load, truck and dollar tracked. Don't partner with people who don't share your vision just because they've got money.

If there's other people's money

The moment someone gives you money, or buys a truck to put in your system, you've got duties to them. Some of these arrangements can be treated as investments under securities law. Talk to an attorney before you take a dollar or make a promise. Keep it clear who owns what, who pays for what, and what's being reported. Never say what a truck will earn.

Sam and Rosa aren't anywhere near this. Rosa's still learning her lane, and that's right where she should be. But she's already writing down how her loads get booked. When the day comes, the playbook's there.

THINK IN CIRCLES

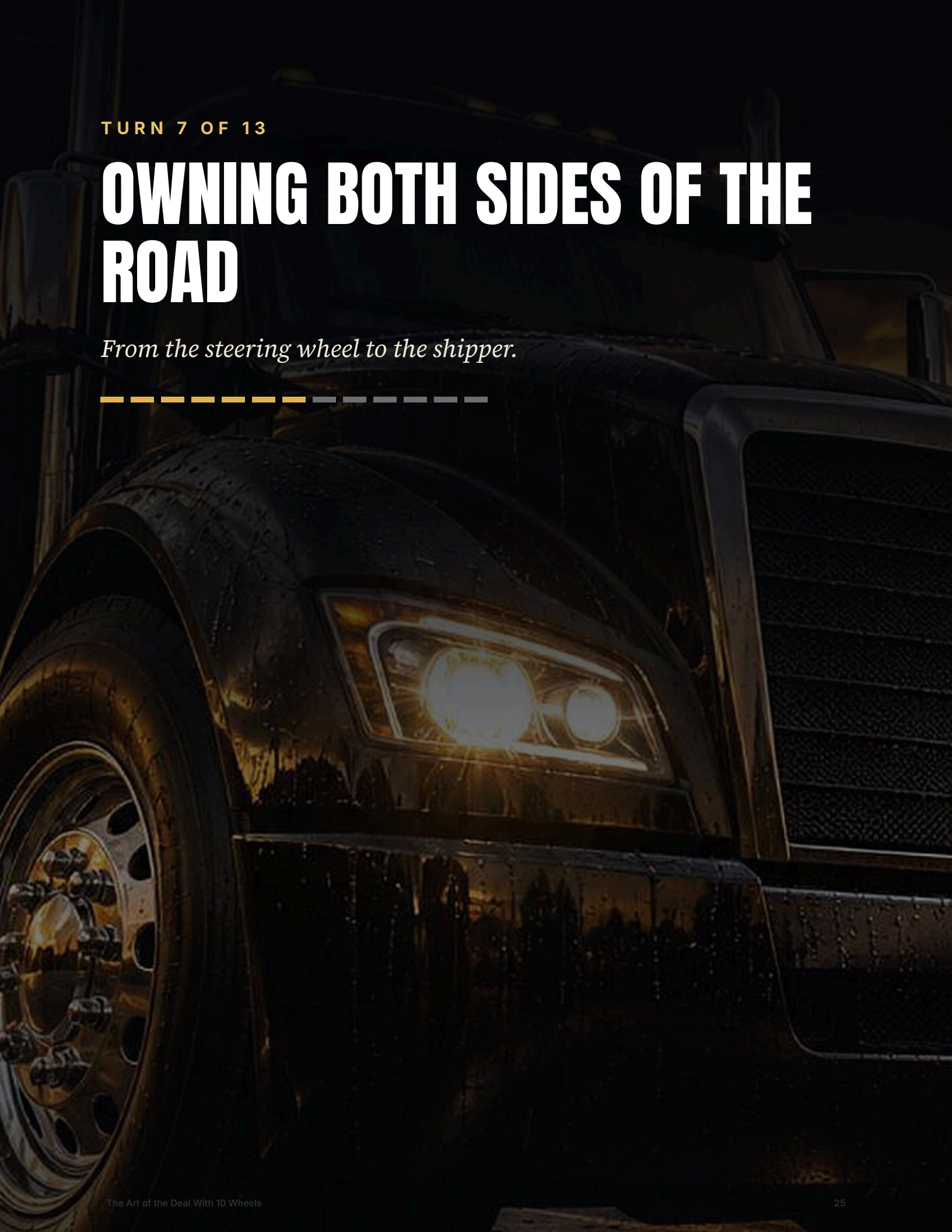
"Passive" is just a loop somebody built well enough that it keeps returning. Build it once, keep watching it, and it feeds you while you work on the next wheel.

> **YOUR TURN**
>
> Write how one load gets done, start to finish, as if you were handing it to a stranger. Where would the stranger get stuck? That's the first page of your playbook.

TURN 7 OF 13

OWNING BOTH SIDES OF THE ROAD

From the steering wheel to the shipper.



The person at the front line of freight is the best one positioned to broker it. I've said that for years, and I wrote a whole book on it called The Shocking Truth. Drivers are on every dock. They know the lanes, they talk to shipping managers and they see what's moving. Why would you waste that?

But this isn't only for drivers. If you own a trucking company or you're thinking about building one, understanding both sides gives you more say over your own freight.

What each side gives you

A freight broker arranges a truck for somebody else's freight, for pay. A carrier hauls it. Those are two different legal things with two different registrations.

- **The trucking side** gives you control and execution. You know the truck's really coming, because it's yours. It also comes with fuel, repairs, insurance, and the question of whether you've got a driver this week.
- **The brokerage side** gives you reach. You can say yes to a load when your own truck's in the wrong state. There's no truck payment. But it's not free or easy. You need your own authority and a $75,000 bond or trust, your name's on the line for every carrier you put on a load, and when a carrier doesn't get paid they'll come looking for you.

Together, it turns

The trucking company gives you credibility, because you understand life on the road. The brokerage gives you customers, and it gives you somewhere to put a load when a truck's down. Your trucks cover your best freight. Other carriers cover the rest. Shippers like working with somebody who can do both, and carriers trust a broker who's sat in that seat.

Now hear me on the order, because it's the same rule. Do one thing and do it the best. Then don't ignore the other. People get this backward. They buy a bond, start cold-calling shippers and then scramble for trucks. We teach it the right way round. Master the profession. Learn the flow of a load. Build real capacity. Then broker. It's the difference between "Can I have a chance?" and "I've got capacity in your area."

That's why you'll hear me talk about a bench, four to six carrier companies and about twenty trucks, before you broker. It's my teaching standard, not a law, and it's in the PLSP Broker course.

Rules for wearing both hats

- **Keep the two separate.** Carrier and broker are separate authorities. When you're brokering, your paperwork says broker, in the name you registered. Don't blur it.

- **Know who has the load.** Never tell a shipper you're the carrier when you're brokering. Never hand a load to another carrier that you agreed to haul yourself without the shipper knowing it's allowed. That's how good people get accused of double brokering.
- **Watch your hours.** If you're a driver, work you do for pay can count as on-duty time under the hours-of-service rule (49 CFR 395.2). Don't log rest in the sleeper berth while you're working the phones for money. Ask your compliance person how to log it before you start.
- **Check your agreement.** If you drive for somebody else, read what you signed before you broker on the side.

Sam's plan looks like this: he's working for Rosa now, as her dispatcher. In time he could become an agent under an established broker or get his own authority. He'll choose when he gets there. Rosa may never broker at all, and that's fine. What matters is that she knows how that side thinks, because she gets a better deal when she does.

I won't tell you what a brokerage earns. I used to write out big numbers on this page, and I've taken them out. Anybody can multiply loads by dollars on paper. What's true is that it depends on your shippers, your carriers and your work, and most people need more time than they planned on.

THINK IN CIRCLES

Owning both sides closes the circle. You find the freight and you move it, and each side feeds the other.

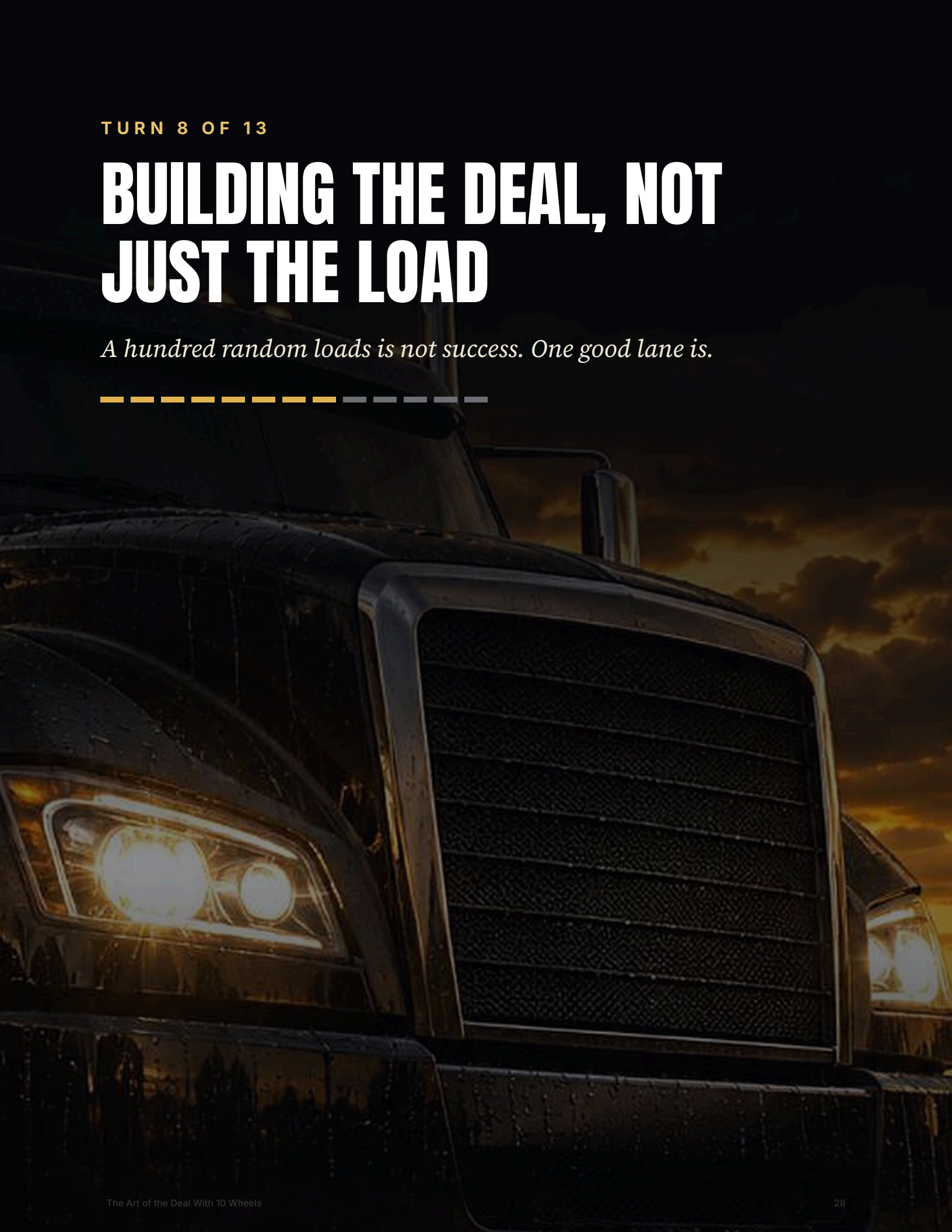
YOUR TURN

Draw two columns: what I know from the carrier's side, and what I know from the broker's side. Which one's shorter? That's what to study next.

TURN 8 OF 13

BUILDING THE DEAL, NOT JUST THE LOAD

A hundred random loads is not success. One good lane is.



Moving a lot of loads doesn't mean you're successful. It means you're busy. I met a man the other day with a twelve-truck company, a real accomplishment on paper. Half of them were sitting. He was working hard every day, and he couldn't tell me what he was building.

What's wrong with chasing the board

A load board's a website where loads get posted. It's useful. You'll learn from it, and a new carrier may have to start there. Read it like research. It'll show you who's posting what, where, and how often.

But it isn't a plan. If your whole business depends on whatever's posted this morning, you get low rates, brokers you don't know, runs that take you where you never meant to go, and cash flow that's different every week. Your driver gets tired of it and your owner-operators go broke on it. I've seen people lose a great deal of money trying to make that work. If that's your only plan, please don't start yet.

What cures it

Freight research. It tells you where the volume is, where rates hold up and which lanes come back. It's what turns a dispatcher from somebody on a phone into somebody who knows something.

Link the lanes

Let me show you what thinking in circles looks like on one truck. Say a shipper has dry van freight going from Georgia to Illinois, but only Monday through Wednesday. You find a carrier who wants Illinois to Texas later in the week. Put the two together and that truck has a reason to be in Illinois, and now you've got a plan for the week, not two random loads.

Five steps from a load to a lane

Here's how Rosa and Sam did it.

1. **Pick one lane.** They picked Memphis to Atlanta, because the research showed dry van freight going regularly. One lane, not five.
2. **Be the one who does it right.** On time. A call before anybody has to ask. Clean paperwork, and an invoice with no mistakes.
3. **Ask the question.** Every single load: "What else do you have coming out of this area?" Follow the freight. It costs you nothing to ask.
4. **Match the driver to the lane.** Let somebody learn the route, the docks and the people. Comfort's a real thing, and customers feel it.

5. **Write it down.** Every load: what it paid, what it cost, whether it was on time, and what went wrong. Use your software or a notebook, but know that lane like it's yours.

Do that for a few months and something changes. A broker calls Rosa before posting the load. Your driver's got a schedule. Your shipper quits worrying. You can plan.

Teach it to everybody

This can't live in one person's head. Everybody in your company should understand repeat lanes and what you learned from last month's numbers. Put it in your weekly meeting.

THINK IN CIRCLES

A load ends at delivery. A deal keeps turning: invoice, payment, repeat, referral. Build the thing that comes back, not the thing that stops.

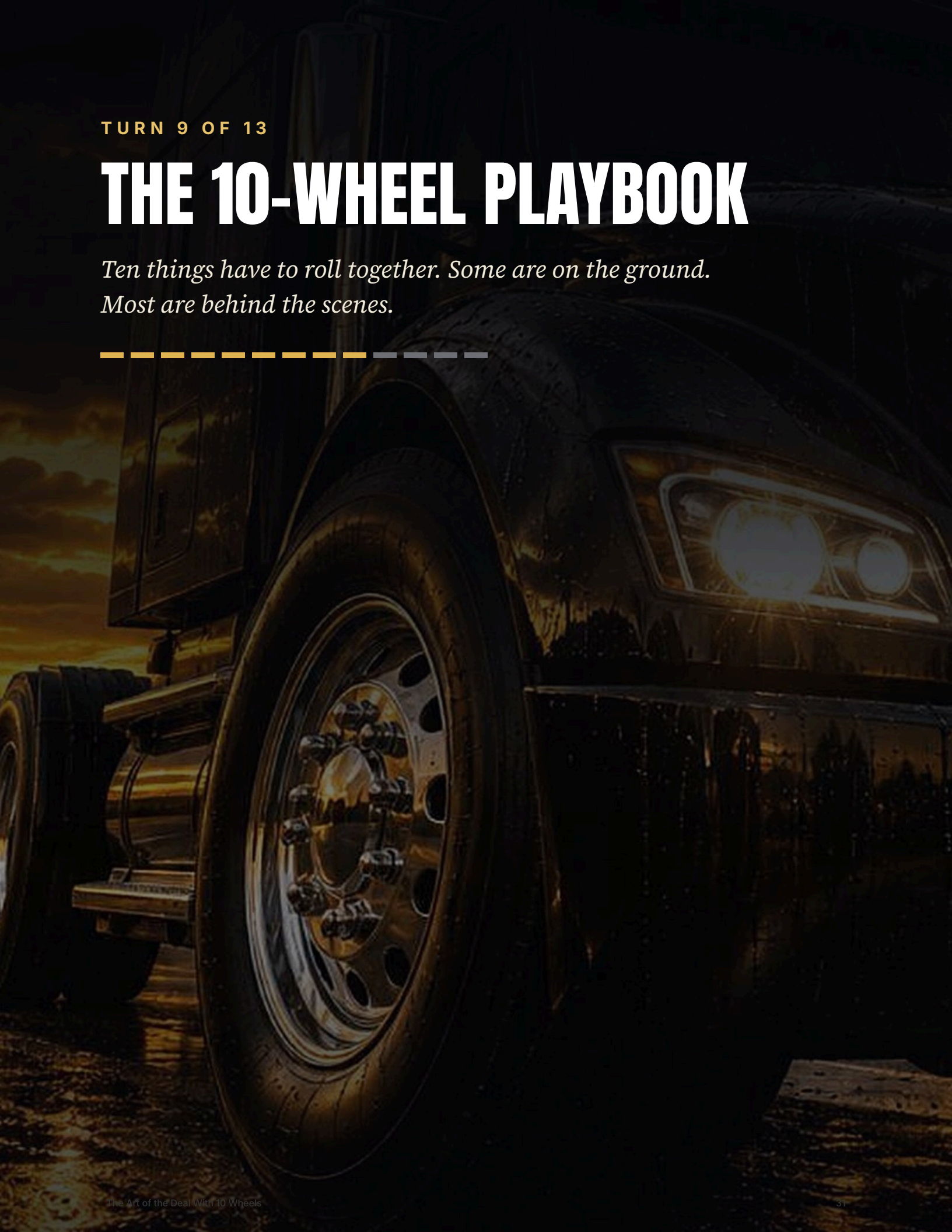
YOUR TURN

Pick one lane near you. Write who ships on it, what trailer it takes, what brings the truck home, and the one question you'd ask to turn a load on it into a second load.

TURN 9 OF 13

THE 10-WHEEL PLAYBOOK

Ten things have to roll together. Some are on the ground. Most are behind the scenes.



I call this the playbook because you can hand it to a team, and run it again in another region. A truck's got ten wheels, and your business has these ten. Go down the list and be honest about which ones are flat.

Wheel 1: The truck. I tell every student and investor the same thing, and I won't change on this one. Old equipment going over the road will bankrupt you. I want newer equipment under warranty. Every breakdown's a late load, a broken promise and a bill. It costs more up front, so run the numbers both ways with real quotes before you sign. If you can't make the numbers work with good equipment, you're not ready to buy yet.

Wheel 2: The trailer. Same thinking. A trailer on the side of the road is a broken promise to a broker. Buy or lease what you can count on, and spec it for the freight you picked in Turn 1.

Wheel 3: Maintenance and vendors. New doesn't mean you can ignore it. Set up your roadside help, your shops, your fuel card and your service calendar before you need them. You're still responsible for inspection and maintenance records, even on a new truck. Don't wait to react. Run your upkeep the way an airline does.

Wheel 4: Technology. Your software should be able to tell you three things: cost per mile, what you made per load, and how many days it takes to get paid. If it can't, you've got an expensive notebook. In our courses you'll see this done in LFS AOS. Whatever you use, those three questions are the test.

Wheel 5: Dispatch and back office. This is your control center. Hire people who know the work, not your cousin. They should book loads with a number in mind, plan routes that fit the driver's legal hours, and know how billing and detention collection work. Detention's the pay for making a truck wait too long at a dock. It only gets paid if somebody chases it.

Wheel 6: Compliance. Your files, your drug and alcohol program, your safety record. Your authority's only as good as this wheel, and it gets its own turn next.

Wheel 7: Your team. The systems don't run themselves. You want people who understand lanes and rates, who are careful with money, and who are pulling the same direction. A trained team's worth a great deal. You build it from the inside out.

Wheel 8: Your numbers. Cost per mile against revenue per mile. Empty miles, called deadhead. Time sitting. What you grossed this week, and what you kept. Look every week, and hold a meeting about it. New trucks cost more, but they're predictable, and being able to predict your costs is worth a lot.

Wheel 9: Training. A business is only as strong as what its people know. Other serious fields train people to a standard, and so should you. Everybody learns the same way, including how the other side of the deal thinks. Put them through the training. Then you

speak one language.

Wheel 10: You. Keep your word, and keep learning. If you're the one who breaks promises, the other nine wheels won't save you.

THINK IN CIRCLES

A playbook isn't steps in a line. It's a wheel you run again and again, sharper each lap. Ask what this run taught you for the next one.

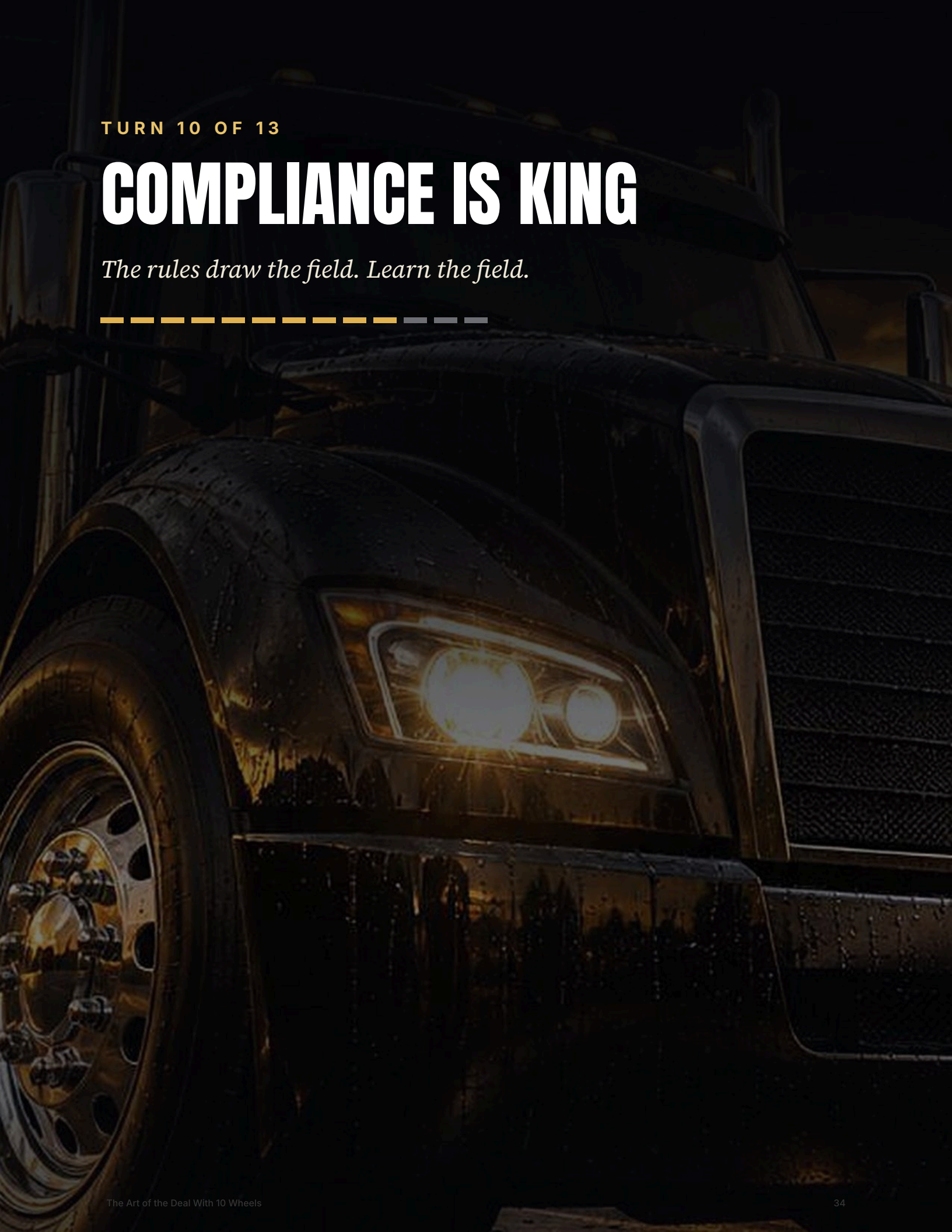
YOUR TURN

Score each wheel from 1 to 5, honestly. Circle your lowest two. Those are your next ninety days. Leave the rest alone for now.

TURN 10 OF 13

COMPLIANCE IS KING

The rules draw the field. Learn the field.



People hear the word compliance and think expense. Think about it the other way. A clean record is one of the few things in this business that keeps working for you whether you're on the phone or not.

What it does for you

Here's what I've seen a good record do. I won't put numbers on it, because yours will be your own.

- Insurance companies look at your record when they set your price.
- Careful shippers and brokers look you up before they book you.
- A record of on-time freight and clean inspections gives you something real to say when you ask for a better rate.
- Lenders and buyers look at it someday too.

Here's something a lot of people have wrong, and I had it wrong in the last edition too. For property carriers, FMCSA's CSA percentile scores and alerts aren't shown to the public. Congress took those off the public display in 2015. But your inspections, violations and crashes are still out there, and people can read them. CSA is FMCSA's safety program. BASICs are the seven categories it sorts your record into. So treat your record like a résumé anybody can pull, because a good part of it is one.

The six things to keep straight

1. **Driver files.** Every driver has a qualification file. The rule requires a review of each driver's motor vehicle record at least once a year, and I like to look more often than that. Track your med card dates so nothing expires.
2. **Hours and logs.** If the miles don't fit legal hours, you don't book the load. Say it to the broker, say it to yourself. The plan has to match what the ELD, the electronic logging device, will show.
3. **Maintenance.** A calendar, not a memory. Deferred repairs come back bigger, and I learned that the hard way so you don't have to.
4. **Drug and alcohol.** Join or run a program, do your random tests, and run the Clearinghouse check on every hire and every year after that. A driver who fails comes off the road right then, and can't go back to driving until the return-to-duty process is finished. Whether you'd ever take them back is your company's policy. Write it down.
5. **Insurance.** Shop it every year, and bring your record with you. Ask your agent what they want to see.

6. **Accidents and bad data.** Keep your accident register. Look into every incident for what caused it. If a violation on your record is really wrong, you can challenge it through FMCSA's DataQs system. It's for fixing errors. It won't erase a violation that's real.

How you make it stick

It starts with the owner. Sign the safety policy first, and talk about it every week. If you don't live it, nobody else will.

Do short training, fifteen minutes, not a whole-day binge. Share the numbers with your drivers so nobody's surprised. Give a bonus for a clean inspection, and you pick the amount. Culture isn't a memo. It's doing the same thing over and over and rewarding it.

As you grow, make it somebody's job. Pick a person who coaches, because drivers respond to partners and they tune out somebody who wags a finger.

A week of it

Here's a simple rhythm. It's my practice, not a law, so fit it to your company.

- **Monday:** Look at last week's inspections and violations.
- **Tuesday:** Check driver files and upcoming dates.
- **Wednesday:** Look at logs and any dash camera or safety alerts.
- **Thursday:** Calls with your insurance agent, ELD company or shop, whichever needs one.
- **Friday:** Short training, plus a note to your shippers on anything they ought to know.

When Rosa's first inspection came back clean, she didn't just file it. Sam added it to the one-page sheet she gives every new broker. Then she paid her driver the bonus she'd promised. That's one inspection doing three jobs.

The law, guidance and my own practice aren't the same thing, and I've tried to keep them separate here. Check the current rule on FMCSA's site before you rely on anything. The compliance lessons in the course go through all of this in depth.

THINK IN CIRCLES

Compliance isn't a cost that ends. It's the wheel that keeps you in the game long enough for everything else to build. Every clean load helps the next thousand.

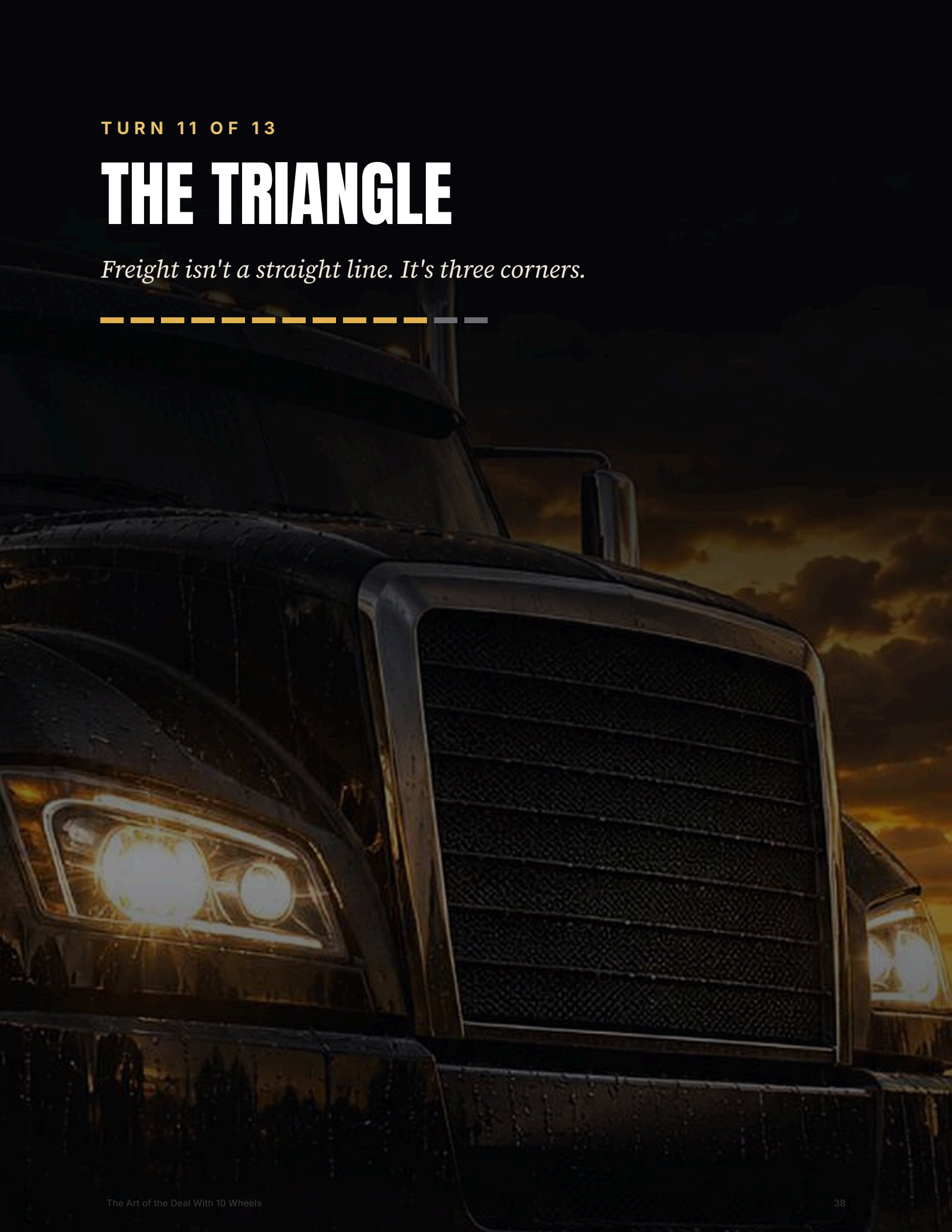
YOUR TURN

Look up your own company on FMCSA's site, or look up a company you know. Read it the way a broker would. What would you ask about? Write down what you see, with the date.

TURN 11 OF 13

THE TRIANGLE

Freight isn't a straight line. It's three corners.

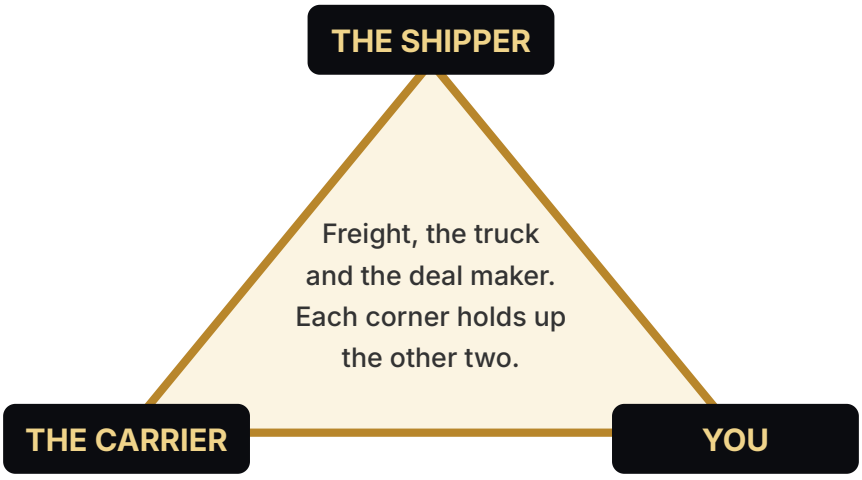


In trucking school they teach you to move a load from A to B. In the real world, the money moves between three corners: the shipper who pays, the carrier who hauls, and the person who brings them together.

The three corners

1. **The shipper.** Has the product, the deadline and the budget.
2. **The carrier.** Has the truck, the driver and the authority.
3. **You.** The deal maker, who turns the freight and the truck into a lane that repeats.

Each corner holds up the other two. Get a good truck and driver and you've got something to offer shippers. Land a shipper with steady freight and good drivers want that lane. Your job is to sit where you can see both.



Corner one: the truck and the driver

Start here, because everything rides on it. Equipment you can count on. A driver deal that's clear. A weekly call, and a home-time calendar the driver can trust. Shippers can tell when a company's steady before you ever say so.

Corner two: the shipper

Shippers want three things, and it usually isn't the lowest rate.

- **Predictability.** A schedule, and a record that shows you keep it.
- **Visibility.** They know where the load is, and they hear about a delay from you first.
- **Accountability.** One person they can call, who answers.

Don't open by quoting a rate. Open by asking about their problems:

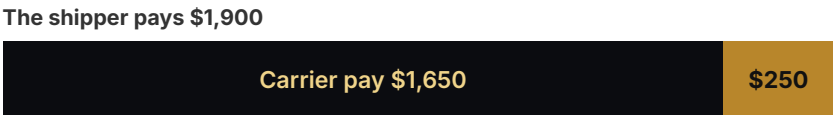
- What are your hardest lanes to cover?
- Do you work with brokers now?
- How do you hand out freight: email, phone or software?
- Do you ever get stuck for a truck at the last minute?

Ask for a small trial lane at a fair rate that you can hold. Run it clean for ninety days. If you've done that, the talk changes.

Corner three: you

The rate has to work for everybody. Remember what margin means, what's left after you pay the cost of doing the work. Here's how it looks when you broker. These are practice numbers.

Load UL-2001, Bluff City Foods to Atlanta. The shipper pays $1,900. The carrier agrees to move it for $1,650. That leaves $250, which is 13.2% of what the shipper paid.



Margin: 13.2% of what the shipper paid. Practice numbers.

The way I look at it, the broker's commission is what the shipper pays minus what the carrier agrees to move the load for. In practice, I think 20% or more is too much. It's your decision, but remember you're building a circle. A carrier who feels squeezed doesn't take your call next time.

If you're the carrier, you do different math: the rate has to cover your cost per mile, your driver and your empty miles home, and leave something. If it doesn't, say no, kindly.

One triangle, then another

Once one lane's working, you've got a choice. Add a truck on the same lane, or copy the whole thing on another lane. Same playbook: a driver who knows it, a shipper who trusts it, and numbers you watch. One lane mastered is a triangle. A few of them in the same region start to look like a territory.

Then more sides appear

I used to call this the octagon. When a triangle's stable, other people start wanting to work with you. A fuel program. A maintenance shop. A warehouse partner. A factoring company, the outfit that pays your invoices early for a fee. Software and insurance people. Each of

those relationships can make the next load cheaper or easier. You don't go chasing them first. They come off the triangle.

Thirty days to your first triangle

- **Week 1:** Settle the truck and driver deal. Decide which numbers you'll watch.
- **Week 2:** Name the top three shippers on your lane, and write what you'd say to them.
- **Week 3:** Win a small trial. Run it clean. Write down what happened.
- **Week 4:** Show them what you did, and ask for the next ninety days.

That's the order, and thirty days is the goal I set. Yours may take longer. Shippers don't move on your calendar.

THINK IN CIRCLES

Three points make one circle. The shipper feeds the carrier, the carrier feeds you, and you feed the shipper. Strengthen the weakest side, and the whole ring turns faster.

YOUR TURN

Draw your triangle. Put a real name on every corner you can. Which corner's blank or weak? That's your work this month.

TURN 12 OF 13

THE DISPATCH COMMAND CENTER

Three circles on a whiteboard run the whole room.



If you're going to run more than one truck, sooner or later you need a real office, even if it's a corner of a spare bedroom. I started with a couple of laptops in a very small room. It doesn't take much. It takes order.

First, the line you don't cross

I'm correcting this one too, so read it carefully. An older edition of this book said dispatch and brokering are the same thing. They aren't. They're two different things, and they stay two different things.

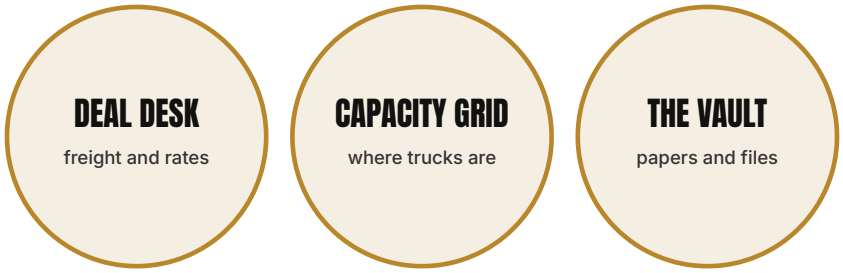
A **dispatcher** works for the carrier. You represent that trucking company. You research freight, negotiate with brokers on the carrier's behalf under the carrier's authority, and handle the paperwork. You get paid a fee for your service. The fee and how you bill it are up to you and your carrier, in your agreement. In our practice case, Sam's fee with Rosa is 7% of the load. My recommendation is to bill through the carrier's factoring company, so you're not always asking your carrier for money. If they don't use one, set up direct billing.

A **broker** arranges a truck for somebody else's freight, for pay, and needs broker authority and a $75,000 bond or trust.

And FMCSA's drawn a line that every dispatcher ought to know. Its final guidance from June 2023 says that a dispatch service that allocates traffic among multiple carriers has to have broker authority. Picture a dispatcher with four carriers, all dry van, all in Memphis, deciding which one gets each load. That dispatcher's choosing, and that starts to look like brokering. Working for one carrier is different, and so is working for carriers whose areas or freight don't overlap. Handling the money between shippers and carriers is another strong sign you need the authority. If you're not sure where you stand, ask a transportation attorney before you take on that second carrier. Calling yourself a dispatch service won't save you. What you actually do decides it.

The three circles

On day one, I drew three circles on the whiteboard. If a task didn't fit in one of them, it didn't belong in the room.



- **The Deal Desk.** Where freight gets found and agreed to. Research, the phone calls, the rate, the rate confirmation. Nothing gets booked without a number in mind and a verified pickup number.
- **The Capacity Grid.** Where every truck you're responsible for is, and where it's going next. Empty miles are the enemy. A sheet of paper can do this for one truck, and you'll want software long before ten.
- **The Compliance Vault.** Carrier packets, insurance certificates, W-9s (the tax form), driver files and agreements. Guard it. One expired insurance certificate can stop a truck cold.

The seats

When you're small, you sit in all of them. That's fine. Just know which hat you've got on.

- **The person making deals.** Knows the lanes and the numbers.
- **The person keeping the vault.** If the paperwork isn't complete, the load doesn't move. A person who likes paperwork is a gift.
- **The person who talks to customers.** The calm voice that calls before the customer has to.

What you can offer without owning a truck

- **Full dispatch service** for a carrier: research, booking, paperwork, check calls and billing.
- **Back office only:** filings, files, invoices and collections.
- **Freight research** for one carrier's truck and region.

All of these use the same three circles. And I'll say it again, emergency truck-finding for a shipper or running several carriers' freight from one list, that's brokering, and you'll need the authority.

How you build one in stages

1. **The skeleton.** Pick your software, a phone and a billing setup.
2. **The carrier.** Get one carrier who's willing to work with you. That's the Catch-22 of starting out: you need a carrier to get freight research going, and you need to know something to get a carrier. Start with one, as Sam did with Rosa.
3. **The papers.** Your written agreement with that carrier. Their packet. Their broker setups.
4. **The freight.** Do the research, make the calls, and book the first load only after the carrier says yes.

Go through the PLSP Dispatcher course when you get to this point. It's built around exactly this.

THINK IN CIRCLES

Dispatch is a loop of information. Every update you send comes back as trust, better freight and better lanes.

YOUR TURN

Draw the three circles. List everything you do in a week inside one of them. What didn't fit? Then write one sentence: "I work for ___, and I am / am not a broker." If that sentence is hard to write, stop and figure out why.



TURN 13 OF 13

THE WAY OUT

Start with the end in mind.

It's strange to talk about leaving a business you haven't started. Do it anyway. The goal was never to stay busy. The goal's choice: how you work, when you work, and someday whether you need to. A good exit doesn't happen by accident. Somebody plans it.

Pick your exit lane

Your destination decides how you build. Here are four, and you can change your mind as you go.

- **Keep it and step back.** You keep the company, put a good manager in place and draw from the profit.
- **Sell it.** You package the real business and sell it to a bigger company or a buyer. The company keeps running under new owners.
- **Spin off the service.** You keep your own trucks and also offer your back office to other carriers.
- **Teach and license.** You license your procedures, your training and your systems to other operators. I said systems. You can't rent out your authority, and we covered that in Turn 5.

Buyers buy proof

Nobody pays for your dream. When somebody looks at your company, they'll want a binder, and you can start one today:

- Your profit and loss statements, reviewed by an accountant
- What each lane pays and costs, and on-time records
- Your safety record, your claims and your insurance history
- Your top customers and carriers, and how much depends on any one of them
- Your written procedures, with dates on them

When a buyer asks, "Can this run without you?", that binder answers. A transportation attorney and a good accountant handle the sale itself. A company can be sold as a real corporate transaction. A number can't.

Build it to run without you

No buyer wants to inherit your job. If it only works when you're in the room, that's what you've got, a job. So start moving yourself out, one piece at a time:

- A manager and leads who can make decisions
- Written procedures for everything that repeats

- A weekly and monthly look at the numbers, so problems show early
- People who are trained and know how they move up
- Backups for people, data and trucks, so one bad day doesn't stop everything

Then test it. Here's a drill I like. One week, hand off all your rate negotiations. The next, hand off the invoice cycle. The next, let your manager present the numbers. In the fourth week, disappear for three days. See what breaks, and fix that.

What makes a company worth more

More than one kind of income. Freight agreements that are written down. A clean safety record. Software that really works. A leader who's staying. Less risk means a buyer will pay more, and less depending on you means less risk.

A rough map

I used to print dollar figures here. I've taken them out, because I can't promise them, and neither can anybody else. Here's the order instead.

- **The first year:** Prove it works. One lane, your written procedures, and knowing your numbers.
- **By the third year:** A company that pays you regularly, with money in reserve, putting some back into people and systems.
- **By the fifth year:** A manager runs the days. You work on the business.
- **Around the tenth year:** Real choices. Keep it, sell it, or sell part and stay on.

Some people get there faster. Plenty take longer, and plenty never do. The ones who get there planned to.

Rosa's got a small company and she's still driving. Sounds silly to talk about selling, doesn't it? But she started a folder. Every clean inspection, every load record and every written procedure goes in it. If she never sells, it's still the best-run one-truck company in Memphis.

THINK IN CIRCLES

Freedom isn't the end of the wheel. It's a wheel that turns without you pushing it. Build the loop that runs on its own, and the way out starts building itself.

YOUR TURN

Choose an exit lane, even if it's only a guess. Write it down and tape it to the wall. Then start your folder today, with one piece of paper in it.

The wheel never stops

If you've come this far, you've got the moves. The moves aren't the point, though. The wheel they turn is the point.

A truck is one wheel. A deal is a bigger wheel. A reputation, a network, a company that keeps running whether you're behind it or not, those are the biggest wheels of all. They all turn on the same idea you started with: everything you do feeds the next thing, and the next thing feeds you back.

The person who never grows keeps starting new straight lines. A load here, a deal there, always beginning again, nothing building. The person who makes it finds where the last step feeds the first and closes it. Then that closed loop pays for the next one.

So don't finish this book. Start the wheel. Make your first decision. Make your first deal. Then ask what it feeds, and keep asking. And whatever else you do, when you tell somebody it's going to happen, make it happen.

A truck moves in a straight line. A business moves in circles.

Michael Thomas
Founder — Logistical Forwarding Solutions | Freight University

About the author

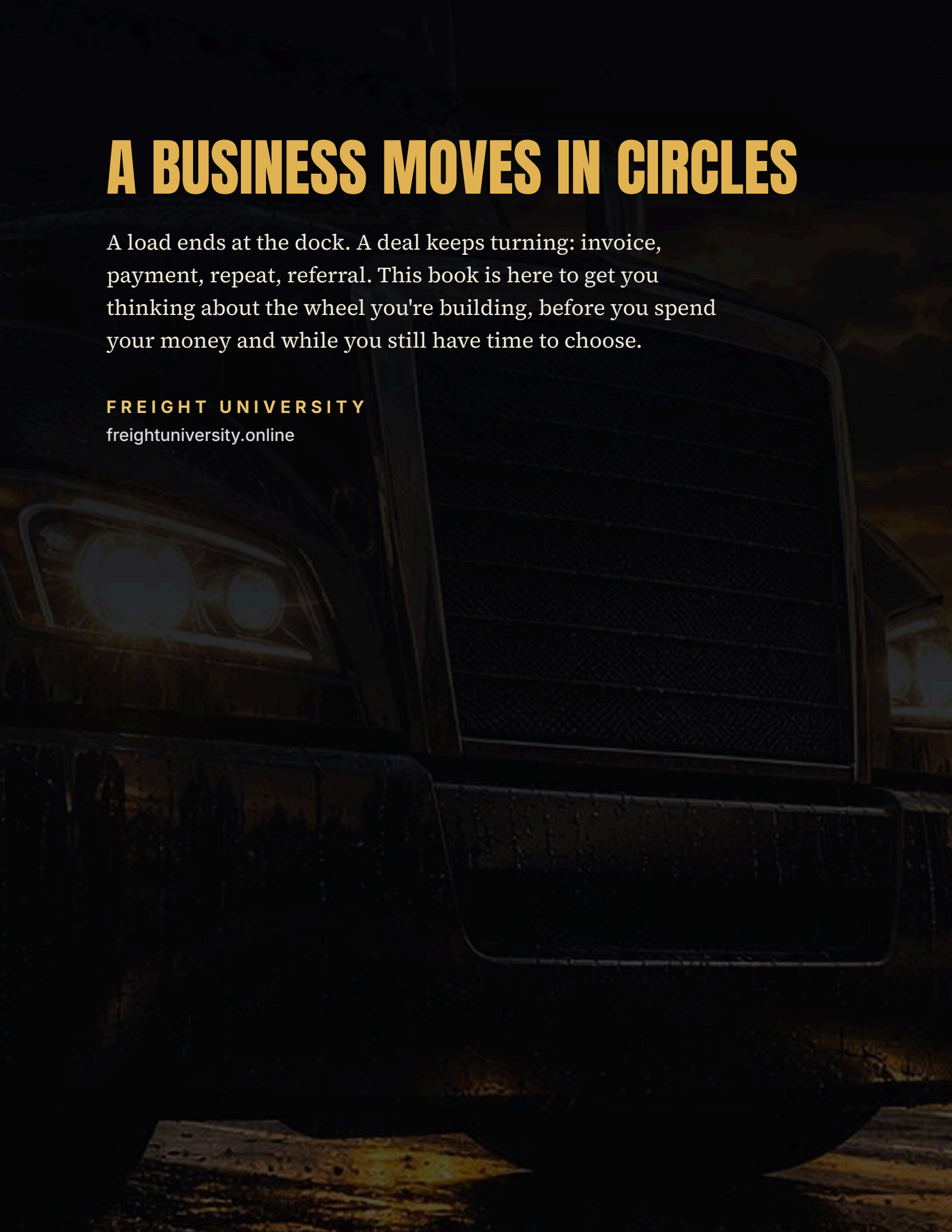
Michael Thomas has spent more than twenty-five years in American freight. He's brokered freight, built and run trucking and logistics businesses, written the Freight University library and teaches the PLSP program. His whole purpose is keeping small trucking companies alive.

Where things come from

Rules change, so check the current page before you rely on anything here. Reviewed November 2026.

- Do not sell, purchase or lease a USDOT number or operating authority (FMCSA bulletin, March 2026): fmcsa.dot.gov/newsroom/do-not-sell-purchase-or-lease-usdot-or-mc-number
- FMCSA on phasing out MC numbers: fmcsa.dot.gov/faq/if-fmcsa-stops-issuing-mc-numbers-will-existing-mc-numbers-be-replaced-usdot-numbers
- Dispatch services, brokers and bona fide agents (FMCSA final guidance, June 2023): 88 Fed. Reg. 39368
- What a broker is and how a broker shows itself: 49 CFR 371.2 and 371.7
- Broker bond or trust: 49 CFR 387.307
- Truck leases: 49 CFR Part 376
- On-duty time: 49 CFR 395.2
- Annual driver record review: 49 CFR 391.25. Clearinghouse queries: 49 CFR 382.701. Removal from driving and return to duty: 49 CFR 382.501 and Part 40
- CSA percentiles and public display for property carriers: fmcsa.dot.gov/fastact/csa
- Challenging a record: dataqs.fmcsa.dot.gov

The stories from my own business are my own experience. The bench of four to six companies and twenty trucks, my views on margin, the weekly rhythm and the exit map are my teaching and practice. None of it is a promise of what you'll earn, and none of it's legal advice. Rosa, Sam and every company in this book are made up for training.



A BUSINESS MOVES IN CIRCLES

A load ends at the dock. A deal keeps turning: invoice, payment, repeat, referral. This book is here to get you thinking about the wheel you're building, before you spend your money and while you still have time to choose.

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY
freightuniversity.online